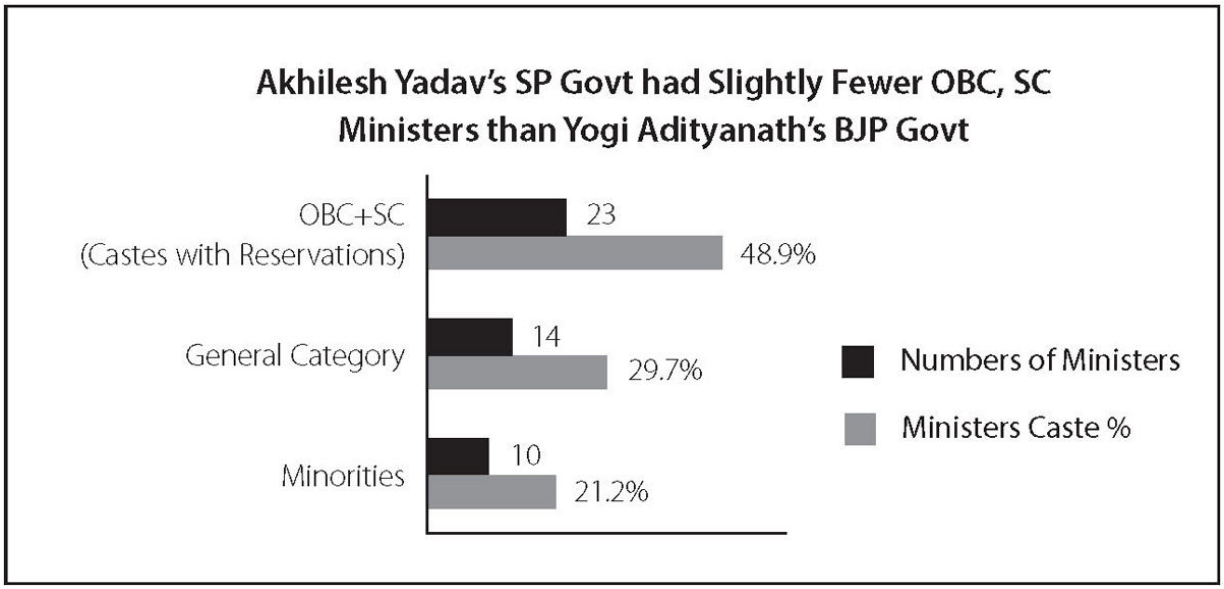


Source: Fieldwork and analysis by Mehta–Singh Social Index. Based on Yogi Adityanath's Council of Ministers list, accurate as of 30 October 2020. Akhilesh Yadav's Council of Ministers as per list issued by UP government in 2012.

The changed representation of these castes in the BJP's political structures—its election candidates, ministers and office-bearers—was part of a planned political outreach. As Dinesh Sharma, UP deputy chief minister, says, 'The work we did at the ground level sent a message at the ground level that while other parties gave caste slogans, we worked on a caste-blind [jaati-viheen] basis. When Jan-Dhan accounts were opened, they were opened for all castes, when toilets were constructed, they were constructed for all castes—for Muslims as well as SCs and backwards. When there is no favouritism in government schemes, people believe it is a casteless structure. SP talks of backwards but goes with only one caste [Yadavs] among backwards. Mayawati talks of Dalits but goes forth with only one caste [Jatavs] among Dalits. Whereas BJP has worked to take along all castes.'[32]

In politics, signalling matters, and one key element of it is leadership structures. For this reason, Keshav Prasad Maurya, a non-Yadav Kushwaha OBC leader from Kaushambi, was made state BJP chief in 2016. Son of a tea vendor and farmer, he cut his teeth in politics as an activist in the Ram Janmabhoomi movement, but first won political office only in 2012 as a first-time MLA from Sirathu.[33]